



FULL-BLEED HERO PHOTOGRAPH
RECOMMENDED: WAIKATO RIVER / HAMILTON GARDENS

— YOUR JOURNEY BEGINS HERE

Waikato Relocation Guide

WRITTEN BY ETHICARE RESOURCING · WAIKATO



Kia ora, and a warm welcome to Aotearoa.

Kia ora, and a warm welcome to the Waikato – the rich river country of the central North Island.

Built along the banks of New Zealand's longest river, Hamilton (Kirikiriroa) is the country's fourth-largest city: affordable, fast-growing and just over an hour from Auckland. The region blends university-town energy with rolling farmland and easy access to the coast.

This guide covers everything you need to settle in – housing, transport, healthcare, finances and where to explore.



Lifestyle / welcome photograph

RECOMMENDED: HAMILTON WATERFRONT OR FAMILY

Nau mai, haere mai ki Aotearoa! (Welcome to New Zealand!)

Ngā mihi nui,
The Ethicare Team

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QUICK FACTS

LOCATION

Central North Island

CLIMATE

Temperate – warm summers

DRIVE TO AUCKLAND

~1.5 hours

MAIN CITY

Hamilton (~185,000)

MAIN HOSPITAL

Waikato Hospital (tertiary)

NEARBY

Raglan, Hobbiton, Waitomo

A river city on the rise

The Waikato spreads across some of New Zealand's most fertile land, centred on Hamilton – a young, growing city built around the Waikato River and one of the country's largest universities.

185K

HAMILTON RESIDENTS

425KM

THE WAIKATO – NZ'S LONGEST
RIVER

1.5HR

DRIVE TO AUCKLAND

Why many professionals enjoy Waikato

- More affordable housing than Auckland
- A major tertiary hospital and medical school
- Central – close to Auckland, the coast and the mountains
- A lively university-city food and arts scene

Heartland and tangata whenua

The Waikato is the seat of the Kīngitanga (the Māori King Movement) and holds deep significance for Waikato-Tainui iwi. The river itself is regarded as a living ancestor.

Hamilton's cultural life centres on the riverside, the celebrated Hamilton Gardens, and a calendar of events including Balloons over Waikato.

Tūrangawaewae Marae at Ngāruawāhia is the heart of the Kīngitanga, and the region's history is told along the Waikato River trails.



Cultural moment

RECOMMENDED: HAMILTON LANDMARK

“

The river runs through everything here – it is the region's history, its boundary and its lifeblood.

ON LIFE IN WAIKATO

Getting around

Here is how people get around Waikato day to day – and what to know about driving in New Zealand.

DRIVING

The Waikato Expressway links Hamilton to Auckland in around 90 minutes; a car suits the spread-out region.

BUSES

Hamilton's BUSIT network serves the city, with the Te Huia passenger train running to Auckland.

AIR

Hamilton Airport offers domestic flights and some trans-Tasman services.

CYCLING

Hamilton's river paths make for scenic, flat commuting and weekend riding.

On the road

- New Zealanders drive on the left
- You can usually drive on a valid overseas licence for up to 12 months before converting to a NZ one
- A local transport card makes buses and trains easy
- Keep your overseas licence and any translation handy when you first arrive

A year in the local climate

The Waikato has a temperate climate — warm, humid summers and cool, sometimes foggy winters. The fertile land owes much to reliable rainfall through the year.

Summer

DEC – FEB

21–26°

AVG DAYTIME

Autumn

MAR – MAY

16–21°

AVG DAYTIME

Winter

JUN – AUG

10–15°

AVG DAYTIME

Spring

SEP – NOV

15–20°

AVG DAYTIME



Seasonal / scenic photograph

RECOMMENDED: RAGLAN / HOBBITON / WAITOMO

Morning fog is common in winter but usually clears to fine days. Summers are warm and good for the region's gardens and rivers. Bring layers for cool mornings.

Healthcare in the Waikato

The Waikato has one of New Zealand's largest hospital networks, anchored by Waikato Hospital in Hamilton — a major tertiary centre serving the wider central North Island.

Waikato Hospital (Hamilton)

A major tertiary teaching hospital (around 650 beds) with acute, surgical and specialist services, and one of NZ's four burns units.

Feeder hospitals

Thames, Te Kūiti, Tokoroa and Taumarunui provide local and emergency care across the region.

Teaching & training

Affiliated with the University of Waikato medical school — a strong base for clinical careers.

Private & ACC

Hamilton has private hospital options; ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone.

Public & private

- Public healthcare is funded through general taxation
- ACC provides no-fault accident cover for everyone
- Private hospitals offer elective procedures and shorter waits
- Many residents hold private health insurance alongside the public system

GPs, pharmacies & urgent care

Registering with a GP and dentist

After you settle in, enrol with a local GP (General Practitioner). Enrolment means subsidised visits — typically around NZ\$50–\$70 when enrolled, more if you are a casual patient. Many practices allow online enrolment once you have an address. Dental care is private; expect roughly NZ\$90–\$150 for a check-up.

Pharmacies

Pharmacies are found throughout the region. Prescriptions are partly subsidised once you are enrolled with a GP — commonly a small standard charge per item.

Emergency & after-hours

- **Emergency Departments** — for urgent or critical care; in an emergency, dial 111
- **Urgent care clinics** — accident & medical clinics offer extended-hours care
- **Healthline 0800 611 116** — free 24/7 advice from registered nurses

Setting up your finances

Getting your finances in order early makes day-to-day life much easier. Most of this can be started before you arrive.

Opening a bank account

The major banks are ANZ, ASB, BNZ, Kiwibank and Westpac. You will usually need your passport, work or resident visa, and proof of a NZ address. Many banks let you start online before arrival, then activate in person. Ask for online banking and a debit card at the same time.

Tax (IRD number)

Every worker needs an IRD number from Inland Revenue. Apply online once you have a NZ address and bank account; processing usually takes around 7–10 working days. Give the number to your payroll team as soon as it arrives so the correct tax is applied. Wages are commonly paid fortnightly.

● Tip

Start your bank account application before you fly — having an account number ready makes your IRD application and payroll setup much smoother.

KiwiSaver & sending money home

KiwiSaver is a government-supported retirement savings scheme. On a work visa you can usually opt in or out. Contributions are a percentage of your pay (commonly 3%, 4%, 6%, 8% or 10%), with employers contributing at least 3%. You can withdraw your funds if you permanently leave New Zealand.

Sending money overseas: banks can transfer internationally, but specialist services such as Wise or OFX are often cheaper and faster. Always compare the exchange rate and the fees before moving larger amounts.

SET UP	WHY IT MATTERS	WHEN
Bank account	Receive salary, pay bills locally	Before / on arrival
IRD number	Be taxed correctly	First weeks
KiwiSaver	Retirement savings + employer top-up	When you start work
ACC	No-fault accident cover	Automatic

What life costs in the Waikato

Hamilton offers big-city amenities at noticeably lower housing costs than Auckland, making it popular with families and professionals alike.

\$560/wk

3-BED HOUSE (APPROX. MEDIAN)

\$2.80/L

APPROX. PETROL PRICE

Left

SIDE OF THE ROAD

EVERYDAY ITEM	APPROX. PRICE (NZ\$)
1 litre of milk	\$2.50 – \$3.50
Loaf of bread	\$2.50 – \$4.00
Dozen eggs	\$7 – \$10
Flat white coffee	\$5.50 – \$6.50
Mid-range meal for one	\$25 – \$40
Monthly gym membership	\$60 – \$100
Home broadband	\$75 – \$100 / month

Prices are indicative and change over time – use the calculators at the back of this guide for a personalised estimate.

An example monthly budget

A rough single-person monthly budget for a Waikato renter. Yours will vary with lifestyle, household size and suburb.

CATEGORY	APPROX. MONTHLY (NZ\$)
Rent (room / small 1-bed)	\$1,300 – \$2,000
Power & water	\$150 – \$230
Internet	\$75 – \$100
Public transport / fuel	\$160 – \$280
Groceries	\$450 – \$650
Mobile phone	\$30 – \$50
Entertainment	\$180 – \$350
Estimated total	\$2,400 – \$3,700

Make it personal

- Use Numbeo to compare Waikato with your current city
- Map your own incomings and outgoings with the Sorted budget planner (sorted.org.nz)

A note from Sophie

A personal word from our Founder on what makes Waikato special — and who it tends to suit.



● SOPHIE'S INSIGHTS

Hamilton is one of our quiet success stories — people come for the affordability and the central location, and stay for the lifestyle. You're an hour from Auckland, an hour from Raglan's surf, and close to a genuinely major hospital.

For clinicians wanting career depth without big-city prices, the Waikato is hard to beat.

Sophie Careem · Founder & Director, Ethicare Resourcing

● From the Ethicare team

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with every step of your move to Waikato — from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Finding a place to live

Hamilton offers riverside apartments, leafy suburbs and new subdivisions, with smaller towns across the region for those wanting space.



Housing / suburb photograph

RECOMMENDED: SUBURBAN STREET OR APARTMENTS

Useful property websites

- trademe.co.nz/property – NZ's largest rental marketplace
- realestate.co.nz – nationwide rentals and homes for sale

A guide to the areas

An orientation to the main areas of Waikato — each with its own character, price point and who it tends to suit.

Hamilton Central & riverside

Apartments and townhouses near the CBD, river paths and dining — walkable and handy to the hospital.

Rototuna & Flagstaff (north)

Newer family suburbs with schools and shopping; popular with professionals.

Hamilton East

Characterful streets near the university and river, with a student-town buzz.

Cambridge & Te Awamutu

Charming towns 20–30 minutes out, with village character and good schools.

Across the wider region

Cambridge

An elegant tree-lined town 20 minutes from Hamilton, known for horses and cafés.

Te Awamutu

An affordable garden town south of the city, popular with families.

Raglan

The famous surf town on the west coast, a relaxed 45-minute drive away.

Morrinsville & Matamata

Rural service towns near Hobbiton, with country living and value.

A tip on choosing

- Think about your commute to work and school zones if you have children
- Where you live can decide which state school your children attend – check the zone before you sign
- Many people rent for a few months first to get to know the areas

Utilities, rates & rubbish

POWER & GAS

Choose from providers like Genesis, Mercury, Meridian and Contact. Compare rates on Powerswitch (powerswitch.org.nz).

WATER & RATES

Council rates fund local services; if you rent, rates are usually included in your rent.

RUBBISH & RECYCLING

Kerbside collection is run by the local council, with separate bins for rubbish, recycling and food scraps.

INTERNET

Most homes have fibre broadband; Spark, One NZ and 2degrees are the main providers.

Set-up quick links

Compare power	powerswitch.org.nz
Post & parcels	nzpost.co.nz
Tenancy advice	tenancy.govt.nz

Where to shop

Waikato offers malls, town centres and weekend markets. A few of the main ones:

The Base (Te Rapa)

One of NZ's largest shopping centres, in the city's north.

Centre Place & Chartwell

Central-city and northern malls for everyday and fashion shopping.

Hamilton CBD & Victoria St

The revitalised central strip for dining, bars and boutiques.

Markets

Hamilton Farmers' Market and Cambridge's markets for local produce.

Supermarkets & groceries

New Zealand's supermarkets fall into a few main groups. Knowing the difference helps you balance budget and convenience.

Pak'nSave

The cheapest of the big chains — a no-frills, bulk-buy warehouse format. Best for budget shopping.

Woolworths

Mid-range and widespread, with strong online shopping and delivery (formerly Countdown).

New World

More upmarket, with a wider fresh and specialty range.

Four Square & FreshChoice

Smaller neighbourhood stores for convenience and top-ups.

Hamilton has Pak'nSave, Woolworths, New World and Costco nearby; surrounding towns have New World and Four Square. Bring your own bags — single-use plastic bags are banned.

Specialty & international food

One of the joys of settling into Waikato is finding the flavours of home — or exploring new ones.

Halal & South Asian

Halal butchers and Indian grocers serve Hamilton's growing community; many supermarket lines are halal-certified.

Asian groceries

A good range of Asian supermarkets and restaurants, especially near the university and CBD.

World food

Hamilton's diversity, boosted by the university, brings a broad mix of international cuisine.

Smaller independent stores open and close over time — a quick search for "halal butcher near me" or your home cuisine will surface the current options near your suburb.

Places of worship

Waikato reflects New Zealand's spiritual diversity, with welcoming communities across many faiths.

Hamilton has churches of many denominations, mosques, Hindu and Sikh temples, and Buddhist centres reflecting its diverse population.

Finding your community

- Most faith communities list service times and locations online
- Many warmly welcome newcomers and visitors
- They can be one of the quickest ways to build a support network when you arrive

A central base for adventure

The Waikato puts surf beaches, glow-worm caves, movie sets and mountains all within easy reach of the city.



Recreation hero photograph

RECOMMENDED: RAGLAN / HOBBITON / WAITOMO

Don't-miss experiences

- Surf the famous left-hand break at Raglan
- Explore the Hobbiton movie set near Matamata
- Wander the world-class Hamilton Gardens
- See the glow-worms at Waitomo Caves

Ten things not to miss

A starter list to get to know Waikato and the wider region.

1 Hamilton Gardens

World-class themed gardens beside the river – and free to enter.

3 Hobbiton

Tour the movie set near Matamata.

5 Waikato River trails

Walk or cycle the riverside paths through the city.

7 Te Aroha

Soak in the historic mineral spa at the foot of the mountain.

9 Bridal Veil Falls

A spectacular 55-metre waterfall near Raglan.

2 Raglan surf

Ride or watch the famous left-hand break at Manu Bay.

4 Waitomo Caves

Drift beneath thousands of glow-worms.

6 Cambridge

Stroll the tree-lined avenues of the 'town of trees and champions'.

8 Sanctuary Mountain Maungatautari

A vast fenced wildlife reserve near Cambridge.

10 Zealong Tea Estate

NZ's only commercial tea plantation, near Gordonton.

Travel from Hamilton

Waikato is a great base for exploring. Some favourite weekend escapes:

Raglan (~45 min)

World-class surf and a laid-back coastal town.

Rotorua (~1 hr)

Geysers, hot springs and Māori culture.

Coromandel (~2 hrs)

Cathedral Cove and Hot Water Beach.

Auckland (~1.5 hrs)

The big city, events and the international airport.

Flying onward

- Domestic flights reach the main centres in around 1–2 hours
- Book early for the best fares on Air New Zealand and Jetstar
- Many regions are also linked by scenic road and rail journeys

Schooling & study

Waikato offers a full range of early childhood education, schools and tertiary study.

Early Childhood Education (ECE)

Kindergartens, daycare, Montessori, kōhanga reo and home-based care for ages 0–5. Government 20-hours funding applies for ages 3–5.

Primary & intermediate

State, state-integrated and private schools for Years 1–8.

Secondary

Years 9–13, working towards NCEA, the national qualification.

Tertiary

Universities and institutes of technology across the country.

School terms run late January to mid-December, in four terms with two-week breaks in April, July and October.

School zones come first

In New Zealand, where you live usually determines which state school your children can attend. For many families, the school decision leads the choice of where to rent or buy.

In-zone = guaranteed

Children living inside a school's enrolment zone are guaranteed a place at that school.

Out-of-zone = ballot

If you live outside the zone you can still apply, but places aren't guaranteed – popular schools run a ballot for limited spots.

Zones are street-by-street

Boundaries can run down the middle of a street, so check the exact address.

● **The order that works best**

1) Shortlist schools you like → 2) Check each school's zone map → 3) Search for rentals inside that zone → 4) Confirm the address is in-zone before you sign.

Childcare for working families

Early childhood (0–5). Daycare, kindergartens, Montessori and home-based care are widely available. The government's 20 Hours ECE funding subsidises care for ages 3–5 at participating centres.

Before & after school (OSCAR). Many schools and providers run breakfast clubs, after-school care and holiday programmes. Subsidies may be available through Work and Income for eligible families.

TYPE OF CARE	APPROX. COST (NZ\$)
Full-time daycare (under 3)	\$350 – \$450 / week before subsidies
20 Hours ECE (ages 3–5)	Up to 20 hrs/week subsidised; extra hours charged
After-school care (OSCAR)	\$5 – \$15 per afternoon, varies by provider
School holiday programme	\$40 – \$60 per day, activity-based

Costs are indicative and vary by provider and suburb. If you'll work shifts, ask providers about flexible hours.

Waikato for families

Beyond school and work, Waikato is an easy, outdoorsy place to raise a family.

FREE & OUTDOORS

Hamilton Gardens, riverside paths and lake walks – free and family-friendly.

RAINY-DAY OPTIONS

Waikato Museum, ArtsPost and the interactive Exscite science centre.

LIBRARIES & PLUNKET

Free libraries run children's programmes; Plunket supports young families.

GETTING AROUND

A flat, easy city with river paths ideal for family cycling.

Settling kids in

- Children often settle fastest through school, sport and weekend activities
- Local clubs – football, netball, rugby, swimming – are inexpensive and welcoming
- They're a great way for the whole family to meet people

Pre-departure checklist

Work through these before you fly. Keep digital and printed copies of everything important.

Documents

- ☐ Passport + valid NZ visa (printed too)
- ☐ Job offer & employment contract
- ☐ Qualifications & certificates
- ☐ References & employment history

Money & travel

- ☐ Apply online for a NZ bank account
- ☐ Documents ready for your IRD number
- ☐ Confirm airline baggage allowance
- ☐ Book temporary accommodation

Your first weeks

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Move into your accommodation | ☐ Open / activate your bank account |
| ☐ Apply for your IRD number | ☐ Get a NZ SIM card |
| ☐ Register with a local GP | ☐ Set up power, water and internet |
| ☐ Learn your transport routes to work | ☐ Save 111 and Healthline in your phone |
| ☐ Find your nearest pharmacy & supermarket | ☐ Explore your local neighbourhood |

● You're not alone

Your Ethicare contact is here to help with any of these steps – from accommodation to payroll setup. Reach out any time.

Key numbers & contacts

In any emergency – police, fire or ambulance – dial **111**.

Emergency & health

Emergency	111
Healthline	0800 611 116
Mental health	Call/text 1737
Police (non-urgent)	105

Everyday services

Tax (IRD)	ird.govt.nz
Immigration	immigration.govt.nz
AA roadside	0800 500 222
Local council	govt.nz/organisations

Banks

ANZ	anz.co.nz
ASB	asb.co.nz
BNZ	bnz.co.nz
Kiwibank	kiwibank.co.nz
Westpac	westpac.co.nz

Community & expat groups

One of the quickest ways to settle in is to find your people. Waikato has active communities for almost every interest and background.

Facebook groups

Search for groups like "Expats in Waikato", your home-country community, and local suburb buy/sell and parents' groups.

Meetup & interest groups

Meetup.com lists hiking, sport, hobby and newcomer groups — a relaxed way to meet people.

Sports & cultural clubs

Local football, netball, rugby and cricket clubs, plus cultural and faith communities, all welcome newcomers.

Workplace networks

Many hospitals and employers have social clubs and buddy systems for new and international staff.

Rainbow / LGBTQ+ community

- New Zealand is welcoming and progressive — marriage equality has been law since 2013
- There are strong legal protections against discrimination
- OutLine Aotearoa offers rainbow mental-health support (0800 688 5463)

Everyday Māori & Kiwi phrases

Te reo Māori is part of everyday life, and Kiwis have their own slang too.

Te reo Māori

Kia ora Hello / thanks

Nau mai, haere mai Welcome

Whānau Family

Hauora Health & wellbeing

Manaakitanga Hospitality, kindness

Mōrena Good morning

Ka kite anō See you later

Tamariki Children

Ngā mihi nui Many thanks

Aotearoa New Zealand

Kiwi slang

Sweet as Great / no worries

Keen Up for it

Dairy Corner shop

Jandals Flip-flops

Flatting Shared renting

Chur Cheers / thanks

Heaps Lots

Togs Swimwear

Shout Your turn to pay

Knackered Tired

Work out your cost of living.

Use these tools to estimate what life in Waikato would really cost for you and your family.

Cost-of-living calculators

Compare cities (Numbeo)	numbeo.com/cost-of-living
Budget planner (Sorted)	sorted.org.nz/tools/budget-planner
Living-costs data (Stats NZ)	stats.govt.nz
Take-home pay (IRD)	ird.govt.nz

We hope you've found this guide useful. Moving to the other side of the world is a big step, and there's a lot to take in – so please don't feel you have to have it all figured out at once.

Whatever stage you're at, we're always happy to talk anything through – the big decisions or the small worries. Just reach out to your Ethicare contact whenever you need us.

Ngā mihi nui

The Ethicare team



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